Research Statement

Montaque Reynolds, Phd

I work in areas of moral and experimental epistemology, primarily with special concern for the relationship between emotion and knowledge. I have published work on the expression of sentiment in popular media, drawing attention to constructions of social identity that entail relational agency through love and regret. I have work purporting to uncover ascriptions of relationships that exist between members of represented characters. By determining the valence, emotions, and other affectual attributions from music lyrics, I have suggested that a more comprehensive project in this area will go further towards determining the portrayed broader cultural attitudes about inter-relational dispositions of a given audience.

I began my PhD studies in 2018. In 2019 and 2020, I was the assistant to the editor of the department's journal, Res Philosophica. Since its founding in 1925 (as The Schoolman), Res Philosophica has been a particularly important publication in academic philosophy. From 2020 to 2022 I was also the assistant to the editor of Schutzian Research, a central publication dedicated to the thought of Alfred Schutz. In both positions, I streamlined the editorial process, enhancing publication efficiency. In part, I adopted an algorithm which extracted bibliography information and encoded it according to latex standards. I also conducted thorough manuscript reviews, ensuring high-quality content. For each issue, I coordinated with authors, reviewers, and editorial board to facilitate a smooth publication process. This enabled me to foster strong relationships and improve communication and productivity. I worked to ensure the authors adhered to submission deadlines, ensuring timely publications.

From 2022 to 2023 I was the graduate assistant for the Walter J. Ong Digital Humanities Center. While there, I conducted digital humanities research, analyzing historical texts using computational methods and techniques from natural language processing. I helped students and faculty develop digital humanities projects. In at least one example project, I helped students design projects analyzing and recovering expressed sentiment from a group of texts considered formative to modern Hindu culture. We built a database to store student annotations of the materials and a website to host the findings and developed data visualization tools to present findings effectively. I also pioneered novel approaches in digital text analysis, integrating machine learning algorithms to uncover hidden patterns in literary works. I often partnered with faculty to design and implement digital projects, enhancing interdisciplinary research capabilities across humanities departments. This required that I meticulously curate and

maintain digital archives, ensuring data integrity and accessibility for future research endeavors. I also applied computational methods to analyze historical and contemporary texts.

I am currently a member of the Saint Louis Digital Humanities Network. This is a group of educators in the Saint Louis area that are committed to exploring ways and implications of expanding use of technology for pedagogical purposes. As our digital technology develops, more and more of our social lives are being conducted through digital mediums. Given that my philosophical interests are motivated by questions about our social environments, these new modes of social interaction are of great interest. I am currently working on developing a philosophy course that I intend to conduct in virtual environments, namely in Massive Multiplayer Online communities (MMOs). I hope to collectively explore implications for conducting our lives in digitally represented social environments by using philosophical reflection to better understand how online communities can be used as a social learning environment.

I have published work on adaptive preferences with members of CUNY's graduate center. https://www.taylorfrancis.com/chapters/edit/10.4324/9781003301424-19/adaptive-preferences-urna-chakrabarty-romy-feiertag-anne-marie-mccallion-brian-mcniff-jesse-prinz-montaque-reynolds-sukhvinder-shahi-maya-von-ziegesar-angella-yamamoto. Additionally, I have 3 projects in draft states: (2025). "Social Agency and other Epistemic Scaffolding"; "Deferrence and The Moral Properties of Imaginative Experience in Narratives"; and "Well-Being and Moral Worth" which explores semantic expressions of well-being in represented human relationships. I also currently have a book titled Play and Meaning, an epistemology of emotional testimony in contract with Vernon Publishers. In it, I explore the view that stories are a form of play that use our emotions to teach us what it means to live well. My current research explores concepts related to imagination and well-being.

During the spring semester 2026, I began using Dave Chalmers' book Reality+ in my intro classes. This book is primarily an exploration of the philosophical method as applied not only to a single question, the simulation hypothesis, but also a way that different areas of philosophy may attempt to answer this question and why these attempts matter for wider academic knowledge. Since then, I have become more interested in the application of this work inside simulated environments. Using various simulated environments, for instance, the Open world Space Sim game Elite Dangerous, I round that my students were able to recognize the gravity of philosophical reflection. Currently, my work is focusing on virtual and simulated environments, for instance, the Classical Ballet, exploring the possibility of works of art inside the space sim Star Citizen, or using embodied LLM agents in Minecraft to better focus on the importance of epistemic justice and social relationships for higher order learning.

I am excited about the opportunity to contribute to a learning environment that engages the student population in meaningful philosophical discourse. My interdisciplinary experience, and philosophical rigor combined with innovative pedagogical methods will be a terrific addition to your department. I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my qualifications and the needs of your department further. Thank you for your time, and for your thoughtful consideration.